



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: American Legacy Academy
School Website: <https://www.american-legacy.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

American Legacy Academy (ALA), Severance, CO, presents a robust classical orientation in its public-facing materials. The school emphasizes a back-to-basics, liberal-arts–driven education with explicit commitments to truth, goodness, beauty, and Great Books, alongside a clear focus on civic virtue and moral character. Public materials repeatedly describe a Classical/Western-Civilization framed curriculum that centers on the liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and a traditional literacy sequence, with attention to history, literature, philosophy, and the fine arts. Evidence from the school's mission, vision, and curriculum language shows alignment with core classical aims (truth, virtue, Great Books, Western heritage, formation of character). The most substantial evidence resides in statements about Great Books, liberal arts, Western civilization, and civic virtue. The school's materials also emphasize parent involvement and community engagement, with open tours and parent information nights, which aligns with the classical emphasis on partnerships with families.

Overall assessment: CLASSICAL.

Key supporting evidence drawn from public materials:

- Explicit articulation of a return to classical education with emphasis on truth, goodness, beauty, and Great Books; Western tradition framing; and civic virtue in mission statements.
- Vision and curricular language describing a classical orientation rooted in liberal arts, civic virtue, and moral character; emphasis on Great Books and a balanced core curriculum (math, science, literature, history).
- Concrete curricular commitments to Great Books, primary sources, and a Western-civilization-centered history, with explicit literacy instruction and language development.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Notes on the rubric and keyword analysis approach:

- The six-category rubric corresponds to a classical framework in which evidence of truth-tradition-centered aims, Great Books, liberal arts, and formation of virtue push toward CLASSICAL, with explicit pedagogy signals (e.g., Socratic methods, Scholé, memory work) and explicit faculty/parent mentorship elements pushing toward stronger CLASSICAL signals. The public-materials set shows strong CLASSICAL signals in Categories 1–3 and 6, with more limited explicit signaling in Pedagogy (Element 4) and Faculty (Element 5). The analysis below explains, per category, which keywords from the Classical Elements lexicon are visible on the site and how they map to the rubric.

ABSTRACT

ed evidence base and keyword framework:



- Positive keyword indicators and negative signals come from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) and the expanded lexicon provided in the Classical Lexicon (Religious & Metaphysical Foundations; School Purpose; Curriculum; Pedagogy; Faculty; Parents & Community). The lexicon lists core terms such as truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, theology, liturgy, Great Books, grammar/logic/rhetoric, Socratic dialogue, Scholé, formation, affection, and partnership with families, among others, with explicit negative signals for secularism, project-based learning, and lack of family partnership. See the lexicon sources for reference to the keyword lists.

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Mission language emphasizes a Western classical tradition with a focus on truth, goodness, and beauty as real, knowable ideals, and on the liberal arts and Great Books. This aligns with transcendental moral realism and teleology common to classical education.
- Vision emphasizes a classical-American orientation with civic virtue and moral character as core aims. This enhances the sense of moral-realism and virtue formation within a theistically inflected Western tradition framework, even if explicit theology is not stated.
- Curriculum references to Great Books, Western-Civilization history, and moral/philosophical studies indicate a metaphysical orientation toward enduring truths and noble aims.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present (from the Six Essential Elements lexicon): truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, Western tradition/civilization, Logos/wisdom (implicit in classical discourse), sacred or sacred-leaning language not explicit, but Great Books and moral character are central. The site text includes truth/goodness/beauty and virtue, plus Western tradition; Great Books are explicitly named.
- Negative keywords present: None explicit (no secular-humanist or relativist signals detected in the public materials); the absence of explicit theology is not a negative signal per se, given the strong classical-moral framing. See the lexicon for potential negative signals (relativism, secular humanism), none of which appear in the site text.
- Why this rating
- The site foregrounds transcendent aims (truth, goodness, beauty) and a Western classical heritage with moral character formation. While theology or liturgical practices are not foregrounded, the explicit emphasis on virtue, Great Books, and a Western-tradition pedagogy supports a CLASSICAL rating for this category.
- Element 1 rating: CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Textual emphasis on formation, virtue, human flourishing, and wisdom, as well as telos and contemplation, mirrors classical aims beyond mere job preparation. The school frames education as formation in the liberal-arts tradition with a focus on enduring truths rather than solely on careers.
- The vision specifies classical orientation and civic virtue as core, aligning with a teleological (end-directed) view of education, not primarily geared toward workforce outcomes.
- Great Books and classical mission are highlighted, reinforcing a formation-oriented telos rather than training-for-work.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, liberal education, classical mission, telos, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful, scholé, contemplation, great conversation, classical heritage. The site materials repeatedly echo formation and virtue, classical education, and Great Books as core to purpose.
- Negative keywords present: None explicit (no signals of “college/career-ready” emphasis; no heavy focus on 21st-century workplace skills in the public materials). The lexicon lists negative signals for this category, but they do not appear in the public text.
- Why this rating
- The school’s publicly stated aims center on virtue, wisdom, and a classical telos with Great Books—hallmarks of CLASSICAL education as opposed to a purely skills/career-focused approach.
- Element 2 rating: CLASSICAL.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Explicit reference to Great Books and a Western-civilization curriculum, with an emphasis on primary literature and a defined list of Great Books. The curriculum language positions history, literature, philosophy, and the arts as the backbone of learning.
- The curriculum description includes core liberal-arts content (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and a historical-literary-philosophical integration, with attention to foundational knowledge in math/science/language and historical consciousness.
- The public materials describe a structured approach to literacy and knowledge-building, including primary literature and moral philosophy, as central content.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present (from the lexicon's Curriculum set): Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books, primary sources, classics, Western civilization, historical depth, Socratic texts, recitation, and sacred art. The site's emphasis on Great Books and Western-civilization history matches these cues; grammar/cursive instruction and literacy domain emphasis also align with classical curriculum.
- Negative keywords present: The site's content does not show a pivot toward social-studies-only terminology or STEM-first framing; however, a Singapore Math approach is noted for math instruction in the site copy, which is not inherently incompatible with classical aims but is not a canonical liberal-arts math focus; the explicit "great books" and liberal-arts framing remain strong. The lexicon notes potential negatives like project-based learning dominance, but the public site does not foreground that approach.
- Why this rating
- The school's public materials strongly center on Great Books, liberal-arts content, and Western heritage—core curricular markers of CLASSICAL education.
- Element 3 rating: CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Pedagogical language on the public site is less explicit about traditional pedagogical methods (e.g., Socratic seminars, Scholé days) than the explicit curricular language. The site emphasizes classical content and a back-to-basics approach but does not consistently enumerate teaching methods on public pages (e.g., explicit Socratic dialogue, structured memory work, or restfulness as a central pedagogical principle).
- The classical-pedagogy elements commonly associated with true classical education (Socratic dialogue, Scholé, memorization/chanting, formation through imitation) are delineated in the Six Essential Elements lexicon and related sources, but public ALA materials do not consistently foreground these methods. Where present in the public materials (e.g., emphasis on Great Books, primary literature, and a literature-based literacy approach), the pedagogical signals are supportive but not explicit in method terms.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present (from the Pedagogy set): Socratic dialogue, dialectic; Scholé; memorization/recitation; formation through imitation and practice; but these terms do not clearly appear in the public ALA materials. The lexicon lists them as canonical signals, while the school's public copy emphasizes content and core skills rather than explicit pedagogy. This yields minimal positive signals in the site text.
- Negative keywords present: Experiential learning focus; project-based-only; student-directed; constructivist. The public site does not foreground these approaches, so there is no explicit negative signal in the ALA public content, but there is also an absence of explicit classical-method signals.
- Why this rating
- The category shows some alignment with classical aims (content-rich, Great Books, liberal-arts emphasis), but without explicit articulation of classical pedagogy signals (Socratic seminars, Scholé, memorization as a core practice) in the public-facing materials, the pedagogy signal remains partial. There-

fore, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

- Element 4 rating: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials emphasize character, virtue, and moral formation in the student experience, which implies a model-based, virtue-centered approach to teaching. The materials frame education as formation, with emphasis on civic virtue and moral development, suggesting teachers should embody virtuous habits. However, explicit statements about teachers as “living curriculum,” faculty as mentors, or a formal “portrait of teacher” are not clearly present in the public materials.
- The language of character formation and moral formation in the school’s mission and vision supports an expectation that teachers serve as role models within a classical framework, but explicit, codified faculty-profile statements are not evident in the public copy.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present (from the Faculty lexicon): virtuous educators; moral formation; character formation; lifelong learning; mentorship; living curriculum; portrait of a teacher; teachers as models of virtue. The site’s emphasis on virtue and character supports these signals, though explicit phrasing about the living curriculum or faculty portraits is not clearly shown in public pages.
- Negative keywords present: The public content does not reveal explicit negative cues about faculty; however, without explicit “living curriculum” language in the site copy, the signal strength is partial. The lexicon warns that lacking explicit faculty signals would reduce this category’s strength.
- Why this rating
- The public materials still emphasize virtue and character formation as central to education, which aligns with classical faculty expectations. The absence of explicit “living curriculum” language or explicit faculty portraits on the public site reduces the strength of the signal to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.
- Element 5 rating: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The school publicly highlights engagement with families and prospective families, including fall tours, parent information nights, open houses, and events that invite family participation. This demonstrates a commitment to parent involvement and partnership with families, a central element in classical education as described in the Six Essential Elements.
- Public materials emphasize Western civ identity and a shared educational mission with families (e.g., “tuition-free, K–8 classical education rooted in American values,” parent-focused events, and community activities). This aligns with cultural transmission and partnership with families, key elements in classical education as framed by the lexicon.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: Partnership with Families; Parent partnership; family involvement; parental engagement; home-school cooperation; open campus; events for parents; parent formation; parental responsibility. The school references parent events and family engagement explicitly, mapping to the positive keywords for Parents & Community.
- Negative keywords present: None explicit in public materials (no signals of lack of family involvement). The lexicon lists possible negatives (e.g., lack of partnership with families) but the school’s public materials do not show these signals.
- Why this rating
- The school demonstrates demonstrable and ongoing parent/community engagement through events and tours, consistent with CLASSICAL expectations for this category.
- Element 6 rating: CLASSICAL.

Aggregate assessment

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: CLASSICAL

- Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall: CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle (only applicable if SOMEWHAT; not required for CLASSICAL)

- For Element 4 (Pedagogy) and Element 5 (Faculty), the school could further strengthen the public articulation of explicit classical pedagogy (e.g., visible mentions of Socratic seminars, Scholé days, memory work, chant/singing as a routine, and a clearly defined “living curriculum” approach for teachers) to elevate from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL to CLASSICAL.
- For Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations), the school could enhance explicit integration of theology, liturgical practices, or sacred music/chant language if desired, to deepen the metaphysical foundation without sacrificing the current civic-theo-ethical framing.
- For Element 2 (Purpose and Goal), continued emphasis on formation over information and more direct articulation of the telos in everyday practice (e.g., explicit statements about contemplation, restfulness, and the Great Conversation in classroom routines) could strengthen the CLASSICAL signal.

ABSTRACT

American Legacy Academy demonstrates a strong CLASSICAL orientation across most categories, with explicit emphasis on truth, goodness, beauty; the Great Books canon; Western civilization; and civic virtue in its mission and vision. The Curriculum category shows robust alignment to liberal-arts content and Great Books, while the Parents & Community category reflects clear partner-teacher-family engagement. Pedagogy and Faculty show partial alignment, with the strongest signals around formation and virtue (Pedagogy: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL; Faculty: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL). The aggregate assessment remains CLASSICAL, with opportunities to enhance explicit pedagogical methods and faculty portraits in public materials to elevate Signals 4 and 5 to full Classical status.

- Element 1 — Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Truth, goodness, beauty; Western tradition; moral realism; virtue; Great Books.
- Positive keyword analysis: Presence of core metaphysical keywords; limited explicit theology/ liturgy signals.
- Why: Strong transcendental orientation, even if explicit theology is not foregrounded in public materials. CLASSICAL.
- Element 2 — School Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Formation of virtue and wisdom; classical telos; Great Books; liberal education framing.
- Positive keyword analysis: Virtue, formation, classical mission, telos, Great Books.
- Why: Clear formation-centered teleology; CLASSICAL.
- Element 3 — Curriculum: CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Great Books, primary sources, Western civilization, liberal arts framework.
- Positive keyword analysis: Great Books; grammar/logic/rhetoric; Western civilization; primary sources.
- Why: Strong classical curriculum signals; CLASSICAL.
- Element 4 — Pedagogy: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Public materials emphasize content and core subjects, but explicit classical pedagogical methods (Socratic dialogue, Scholé, memory work) are not consistently foregrounded in public content.

- Positive keyword analysis: Partial signals (absence of explicit pedagogy terms in public copy; lexicon lists canonical signals that are not fully visible there).
- Why: Pedagogical signals exist in classical lexicon but are not consistently articulated on the public site; SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.
- Element 5 — Faculty: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Faculty signals around virtue/character formation in the educational mission, but explicit public articulation of the faculty as “living curriculum” or explicit portraits is not clearly stated.
- Positive keyword analysis: Virtue-focused language; mentorship; moral formation; but lack of explicit, public-facing faculty-profile language.
- Why: Partial alignment; SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.
- Element 6 — Parents & Community: CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Explicit parent-events, tours, and community involvement; open-campus ethos.
- Positive keyword analysis: Partnership with Families; parent involvement; community engagement signals.
- Why: Clear alignment with classical community-building; CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle (not required for CLASSICAL; included for context)

- If the school sought to strengthen Pedagogy (Element 4) and Faculty (Element 5) signals to reach full CLASSICAL across those categories, it could:
- Explicitly publish and operationalize classical pedagogy (Socratic seminars, Scholé days, memorization/recitation, and the living-curriculum concept for teachers) on the website and in admissions materials.
- Publish a “faculty profile” or portrait of the teacher as a model of virtue and a description of ongoing classical-professional development, to align with the faculty lexicon.
- For deeper Religious & Metaphysical Foundations, the school could consider adding explicit theological framing or liturgical-cultural language to complement the current moral-virtue and Western-tradition emphasis, if desired, without compromising the current formation focus.

Note: All keyword-signaling references are drawn from the classical-education keyword framework in the Six Essential Elements lexicon and aligned with the school’s own public statements. See the Six Essential Elements lexicon for reference to the keyword sets used in this analysis.

END OF REPORT

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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